

TNF

# FAT LOSS & BUILDING PHASES

The effective guide to getting control of your physique



# INTRODUCTION

First things first, I want to say thank you. It's due to you guys that I am able to do what I do, and I love being a part of all of my followers' journeys, whether that's physical, or mental. This manual is not only meant to help you take control of your fat loss journey, but is also meant to guide you coming out of it. It's often easy for people to shed some fat, but much more difficult to keep it off. This manual is meant to provide you tools to allow for long term sustainable fat loss. BUT, it is not a heal all. It will take dedication and fortitude from the user. **My words can only do so much. However, if you trust the process, I can promise you that you will be well on your way to achieving a lean aesthetic physique.** Thank you for putting your trust in me and I'm looking forward to seeing the outcomes!

**Disclaimer:** None of this is medical advice and you should always consult a healthcare professional before taking on any type of dieting or strength training program.

# 10 STEPS FOR LONG TERM SUCCESS

These are 10 basic steps that I want you to go over before we get into more specifics. If you were to fully do/understand these 10 steps alone and leave the rest of the manual, you would already be well ahead of the general populace. Let's dive into it.



## STEP 01. SELF ASSESS

This is often a difficult one for people, but I hope to make it as digestible as possible. Long story short, you have to be honest. One of the most common tropes that I see within my coaching is people being disillusioned about their current state. Whether it's the 250lb 5'9" man who thinks they will be seeing their abs if they lose 15lbs, or it's the 5'6" 180lb woman who swears she's been eating 1000cal a day for months/years and not losing weight.

The problem with both of these individuals is they've been fed lies. The lie of getting abs with a few weeks of hard dieting in the man's case, and the lie of the body refusing to let go of fat due to "starvation mode" in the case of the woman. **Luckily, with a proper understanding of biology, ANYONE can lose fat and keep it off. And while the process may be significantly more difficult for some than others, through time, effort, and understanding every single person can get to a healthy and aesthetic body fat.**





Here an important distinction must be made. If you are thinking that you are going to get down to stage bodybuilder body fat levels and maintain that year round, you're out of your mind. Very few are capable of doing this, and even fewer are capable of doing it in a healthy manner. If you're about to ask me if you're the exception, I'm going to stop you right there. You're not. You wouldn't have purchased a fat loss manual if you had that ability. We clear? Good. **This manual is not to be abused by people attempting to look absolutely shredded year round at the expense of their health. Focus on a realistic goal and work towards it.**

If you've spent the last decade at 30%+ body fat, aim for 20% (any percentages that I say for men you can simply add 10 for women).. Can you go further eventually? Of course. But right now your main objective should be health, not being the most shredded guy at your local LA Fitness. If you're 20%, feel free to play around with 11-14% body fat and see how that feels for you. If you're 10-12% body fat, put this freaking manual down and do some self reflection. Because unless you're competing in bodybuilding or you have a model shoot coming up, you aren't doing yourself any favors trying to get to and stay at 4-9% body fat. It's a select few that can stay single digit bodyfat comfortably and those that can typically aren't purchasing fat loss manuals. If you have no idea what your current body fat is, that's ok. If you would describe yourself as skinny fat, pudgy, overweight, obese, etc...you can definitely stand to lose some fat and will benefit from this manual.



## STEP 02.

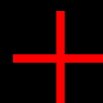
# HAVE ACCOUNTABILITY

Talk to someone. One of the main mistakes I see when people attempt to take on a large task is that they try to do it alone. Now this doesn't mean the person you talk to has to be on the same journey as you. Not at all. But they should know you, your struggles, your insecurities, and they should be able to hold you accountable.

## STEP 03.

# CHANGE YOUR MINDSET

It's ok to try new things. I'm not against that at all. But understand this. If you are making a change to drastically alter your physical status from what it has been for a long time, you have to be committed. There is no "ifs", "ands", or "buts". You either make the decision that this is something you're fully committed to or you watch yourself dip your toes in and fail miserably. I know this sounds harsh, but I'm giving you the reality of the situation. If you are not someone who stays lean/fit easily, you're going to have to live differently. You will have to make many decisions along the way. **This WILL mean sacrifice. This WILL mean restriction. Any bull crap that you hear online saying otherwise is exactly that. Bull crap.** This does NOT mean you can't enjoy the journey. This does NOT mean you won't have opportunities to indulge. But if you think you are going to look and feel substantially different than you do now with no curtailment to your current lifestyle, prepare for failure.



## **STEP 04.**

# **UNDERSTAND HOW FAT LOSS WORKS**

There's no need for us to get into the technicalities of the chemical process behind lipolysis (fat breakdown), but we will talk through the generalities so you can understand what's happening under the surface. Each day you are going to utilize a certain amount of energy. We generally measure this energy with a unit called a calorie. It is simply the heat energy needed to bring the temperature of 1g of water up by 1 degree celsius. The Calorie that you see on your food boxes is actually a kilocalorie (1 thousand calories). To keep things simple, when I say calories it will **ALWAYS** be in reference to the calories you would see on a nutrition label. The formal calorie as a unit is too small to be practical.

Your body metabolizes food and drink that contains carbon atoms. This is why things like table salt, that only contain sodium and chloride contain zero calories. There are 4 primary carbon containing molecules that we use for physical processes. We call these macronutrients and each macronutrient contains an approximate number of calories. They are as follows.

**+ Carbohydrates-4 cal**

**+ Protein-4 cal**

**+ Fat-9 cal**

**+ Alcohol-7 cal**





This should go without saying, but if your goal is fat loss/health, alcohol is not helpful in any regard. This is not to say you can never consume it and still lose fat. But it plays no useful role within the human body. As such, we aren't going to talk about it at all other than to make sure you understand it packs a caloric punch while being nutritionally detrimental.

If the total carb/pro/fat/alc calories that you consume in a day is less than your daily expenditure of calories, you will lose tissue. The reason is simple. **Your body can't perform its functions without energy. This energy will have to come from the food/drink OR the tissue on your body. If there isn't enough overall calories coming from the food/drink, your body has no choice but to steal from the energy stored in your body to meet those demands.** It can take from both fat and muscle. It will preferentially use fat, but there is a risk of some muscle loss if the body doesn't sense a need for the muscle to remain. This is why resistance training, adequate protein, and proper rest is essential to keeping muscle while being in a fat loss phase.

To sum up, fat loss is incredibly simple, not easy, but simple. You must consume (or at the very least metabolize) less calories in a day than you expend. And in order to keep or even possibly build muscle while losing this fat, you must have adequate stimulus (resistance training), nutrition (primarily enough protein), and adequate rest (primarily sleep). Note that I didn't mention cardio at all. **Because cardio can HELP you lose fat, but it is not NECESSARY.**



## STEP 05.

### UNDERSTAND YOUR LIFESTYLE

This is probably the most highly underrated and overlooked aspect when it comes to fat loss. **People often try to shove themselves into a narrow box that they will never be able to fit.** If you're someone who spends all their time traveling and outside the house, don't expect to be able to meal prep constantly. If you hate certain foods, don't expect to be able to stick to a diet that mainly consists of those foods. **This is why it is so important for you to understand how fat loss works and how to adapt the principles to YOUR situation.**

## STEP 06.

### DROWN OUT THE NOISE

There will be many people who will not understand you or what you are trying to accomplish. Never let them make you feel bad for striving for a goal. People often try to bring others down around them, particularly when they feel inadequate themselves. However, do NOT vocalize this to those who tell you "come on", "just try it", "it's just one day"... You are trying to regain control of your physique, not lose all your friends. **If you decide to stray from your typical diet it should be YOUR decision. No one else's.**



## **STEP 07.**

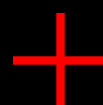
### **LISTEN TO YOUR BODY**

I know that sounds crazy coming from me. But I mean something very different from your typical intuitive eating body positivity activist you see plastered all over social media. There are different warnings you should be looking for while dieting. The main ones are sleep, performance, and libido. If your sleep takes a massive hit while dieting, you should reassess your dieting techniques. Same thing with performance in the gym or your sexual drive. A variety of things can cause this which we will talk about, but for now just understand that you shouldn't simply grit your teeth through these symptoms. They will typically require a change in approach.

## **STEP 08.**

### **SET YOURSELF UP FOR SUCCESS**

If you know certain people or things can drag you down, remove yourself from those variables as much as possible. The number of people that have told me they struggle to lose weight, yet have chips or cookies in their pantry is astounding. There are many ways that people set themselves up for failure. **Think through the things that have caused you to fail in the past and remove as many of those stumbling blocks as you can.**



## STEP 09.

# LEARN HOW TO FLEXIBLY HIT GOALS

You will not have the perfect circumstances 24/7. **If you can't reasonably hit goals while out of the house, on vacation, visiting family, that is a CHOICE.** Don't throw your hands up. Plan ahead. Think through the circumstance and what you need to do to reasonably accomplish what you need to in ALL circumstances. This can be as simple as bringing protein powder with you when you travel and controlling portion sizes when you have no control over the food, or if you need to/the situation allows it, full on meal prepping. Adapt to your circumstance and don't give yourself excuses.

## STEP 10.

# REFLECT OFTEN

**This one is INCREDIBLY important. Continually assess your mental state throughout your journey.** Are you becoming too obsessive? Are you scared to eat food if it's not weighed out on a scale? Do you refuse to ever go out because you can't follow your meal plan? Are you insulting those around you by acting like you are superior for choosing a different lifestyle? Many of these things can creep in and cause serious damage long before a person notices it themselves. **If you are dealing with any of these things, GET HELP. Do not struggle in silence.** Find support and work through these issues.



# HOW TO BEGIN

Before I start this, I want to make one thing very VERY clear. Calories **DO** dictate weight loss/gain. However, this sentiment has been so thoroughly abused, that many people have completely tossed out any semblance of health in their pursuit of a lean physique. Ironically, by doing so they either fail to lose weight entirely, or shortchange their muscular development in the process. On the other hand, there are many who say as long as you eat “healthy” you’ll never need to track calories. While there will be some who can completely neglect one or the other and achieve a great physique, **most will need some level of tracking ALONG WITH quality choices in order to achieve their best.**

The food choices that will be best for you is going to be dictated by a few factors. But by far the biggest one for people looking to lose weight is long term satiety. The reason the majority of diets fail is due to **HUNGER**. My primary system for weight loss can be described by the following initialism: **VMFCOJ**.

**The reason I came up with this is because nearly always when someone is struggling to lose/keep weight off, these are the least problematic to most problematic food types in order. Understand this is generalized and it could be slightly different for some people. However, the vast majority of the time, it simply comes down to a lack of prioritization within diet.**

So let’s go through this acronym and what it means for you.



## V IS FOR VEGETABLES

No one is fat because they're binging vegetables. I don't care which Carnivore Calvin told you that they were eating soooo many vegetables and couldn't lose weight... it just isn't happening. And when I refer to vegetables I'm mainly referring to leafy greens, zucchini, asparagus, broccoli, celery etc. So if you are someone who is struggling to keep their weight in check, increase the amount of veggies in your diet. Whether this is through salads, cut up vegetables, cooked veggies...Find a way to make it happen. And if you hate vegetables it is because you have a 5 year old's pallet. You should actively work to change this. Food preferences are not set in stone the way people believe. They can be learned to a great extent. Even if it just means sneaking the vegetables into other foods slowly over time to stomach it better, find ways to make it happen.



## M IS FOR MEAT

Now this one will be slightly controversial I'm sure (I mean vegans do exist), but rarely is someone overweight because they are consuming too much HIGH QUALITY meat. Of course you can add a bunch of stuff to meat to run up the calorie amount or be eating processed meats, but if we are talking about meat in and of itself, it is rarely the issue. Now if you do find you tend to over-consume on meat, even high quality meats, moving towards leaner cuts will make it harder to run up the calorie amount. Eggs/seafood also fall under this heading. Cheese and dairy not so much. If there's one animal based protein I have consistently observed people struggling to moderate, it tends to be dairy products. This is not saying they are bad. But for the purpose of weight loss, be a bit pickier when choosing your dairy choices to consume consistently.





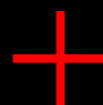
## F IS FOR FRUIT

I debated whether to put this before or after meat for a good amount of time. Eventually I decided to put it after for one simple reason. A complete lack of protein. So while fruit may be more satiating than meat on a calorie equated basis, it is less important dietarily for someone concerned with body composition. Quick side note, if you do want to have more fruit in your diet for less calories, your tracking apps will allow you to figure out which fruits are the lowest in overall calories on a gram for gram basis.



## C IS FOR CARBS

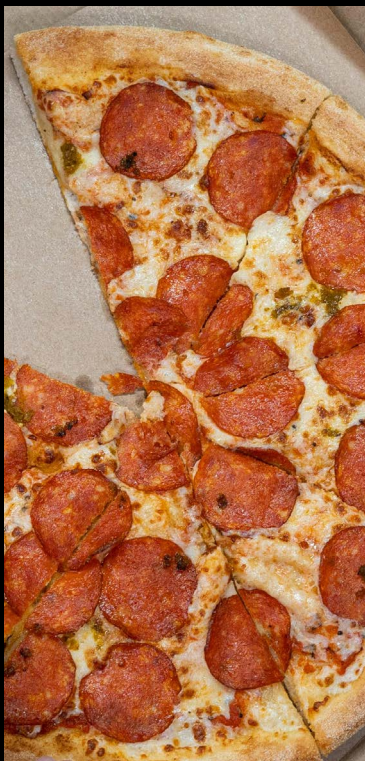
Now please don't misunderstand me, both veggies and fruit are primarily carb sources in terms of macronutrients. But the carbs I am referring to are those that come with less water, pectin, micronutrients, and in some cases fiber than fruits and veggies. I am mainly referring to things like rice, noodles, flour, grains, potatoes, etc. And while there is nothing inherently wrong with a lot of these foods, particularly whole grains and potatoes, the ease with which people over-consume these sources of carbs relative to fruits and veggies is palpable.





## **O** IS FOR OIL (EASY FAT SOURCES)

To be clear, this is NOT me saying all oil needs to be avoided at all times in order to achieve your goals. But nearly always those who are obese/morbidly obese become so, at least partially, due to an overconsumption of readily accessible oils and fats. Think about some of the tastiest foods you can. Often these foods are loaded with oils, or other fats to make them hyper palatable. Sauces, dressings, donuts, chips, peanut butter...all of them use oil or high amounts of fat to accomplish a smooth texture and taste that we just keep coming back to. When people cook and want their food to taste better, they use oil. Which not only makes the food more palatable, it also increases the calories very quickly.



## **J** IS FOR JUNK

Yes, there is such a thing as junk food. No, this does not mean you are a bad person for consuming it. You can recognize both things simultaneously, but people are very extreme so they tend to go all in one way or the other. Junk overlaps with oil a lot. Many junk foods contain oils and easy to overconsume fatty products. But it can also be things that are primarily sugar based. Candy, soda, etc. I would also be likely to put many fruit juices and sugary drinks into the junk category. If you have to ask, it probably fits into this category. AGAIN, this does not mean you can never have junk and reach your goals. In fact some people will find that some addition of junk helps them stay on track. But it is very clear that diets that are high in junk tend to lead to the worst outcomes.





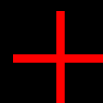
## HOW TO USE **VMFCOJ**

Assuming you get enough protein, simply leaning into foods higher up the list while attempting to lose weight or when you're struggling with hunger will be one of the easiest ways to manage body fat levels. I use this method to diet and "reverse diet" myself and many of my clients. But the only way to do this is to view food differently than the majority of the population. We have been so conditioned to view food a certain way, that many people can't fathom going outside the status quo.

The typical Western meal finds itself in the C, O, and J categories, when we would be much better off having the majority in the V, M, and F categories. The reason for this backwards dietary habit is simple...EFFICIENCY. C and O foods are often cheap, readily accessible and very tasty. A lot more thought/effort needs to go into the V and M categories in terms of preparation as well as often being more expensive per calorie.

This is not to say that you can't lose and keep weight off affordably if you're smart with your choices, but high quality meats and vegetables will most definitely cost more than low quality C/O/J meals. It is a few years old but this is a crude list of the most effective calories per dollar items at the grocery store taken from [efficiencyiseverything.com](http://efficiencyiseverything.com). Doesn't take long to figure out why our meals lean towards carbs, oils, and junk.

And here's some even more telling graphs of commonly bought foods with one snapshot from closer to the top and one from closer to the bottom. The nice thing is, we do not HAVE to consume solely expensive foods in order to accomplish our goals. They are tools, but that is all. Everyone will have to work within their own budgetary confines to determine what they are capable of.



| Item                             | Before Tax Price | Calories Per Dollar |                            |         |       |
|----------------------------------|------------------|---------------------|----------------------------|---------|-------|
| Flour                            | \$1.68           | 4,464               | Pinto Beans (10lbs)        | \$9.12  | 1,026 |
| White Bread                      | \$0.78           | 3,333               | Goldfish Crackers          | \$7.99  | 964   |
| Sugar                            | \$2.98           | 2,854               | Dr. Thunder                | \$0.84  | 952   |
| Rice                             | \$6.53           | 2,320               | Whole Wheat Bread          | \$1.48  | 946   |
| Plain Oats                       | \$7.89           | 2,148               | Lentils                    | \$1.12  | 929   |
| Ramen                            | \$2.34           | 1,949               | Olive Oil (Costco)         | \$25.99 | 923   |
| Angel Hair                       | \$1.00           | 1,600               | Whole Milk                 | \$2.59  | 902   |
| White Pasta                      | \$1.00           | 1,600               | Flour Large Taco Shells    | \$2.38  | 882   |
| Bread Crumbs                     | \$1.08           | 1,556               | Bagels                     | \$1.48  | 851   |
| Peanut Butter                    | \$10.99          | 1,487               | Large Heavy Whipping Cream | \$3.78  | 847   |
| Whole Wheat Pasta                | \$1.00           | 1,470               | Eggs (Costco)              | \$3.59  | 802   |
| Pearled Barley                   | \$0.98           | 1,429               | Kraft Mac And Cheese       | \$1.00  | 780   |
| Extra Virgin Olive Oil 101fl oz. | \$19.28          | 1,245               | Instant Oatmeal            | \$1.68  | 762   |
| Chocolate Frosting               | \$1.48           | 1,230               |                            |         |       |
| Cheez-its                        | \$5.49           | 1,230               |                            |         |       |

# CALORIES

So you've determined your budget, you've resolved to consume more vegetables, meat, and fruit where possible. But how do you go about tracking food and accomplishing your goal. First things first, you need to determine a calorie amount that makes sense. There are so many calorie calculators out there and if you want to use one you can, but I find this to be a slightly easier way of going about things.

## MALE:

Under 200lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories: 10-14x bodyweight

200-250lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories: 9-12x bodyweight

250-300lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories: 8-10x bodyweight

300-400lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories 7-8x bodyweight

400+lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories 5-7x bodyweight

## FEMALE:

Under 150lbs Goal → Weight Loss → Calories 11-16x bodyweight

150-200lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories: 10-13x bodyweight

200-250lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories: 9-12x bodyweight

250-300lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories: 8-10x bodyweight

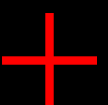
300-400lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories 7-8x bodyweight

400+lbs: Goal → Weight Loss → Calories 5-7x bodyweight



You probably noticed that the relative proportion of calories to bodyweight went up with lighter individuals. This is because TYPICALLY (there are obviously exceptions) the smaller you are weight wise, the higher the percentage of lean mass on your frame. Contrary to what many people have taught you, a larger person (fat wise) can physically thrive on a lower amount of calories relative to their weight. Why is this? Due to the large amounts of stored energy they have on their body. While mentally they may find a caloric deficit even more difficult than a leaner person, physically there is less probability of negative outcomes.

The recommendations above are how many calories you should be consuming each day of the week **ON AVERAGE**. Some people prefer to have lower and higher days to fit their lifestyle or schedule. A common way to do this is to eat a little less during the week to be able to have a slightly higher allowance for the weekend. As long as the average number of those 7 days is hitting your calorie target, you will be on track. **HOWEVER**, I advise against super low to no calorie days simply due to the fatigue and lack of protein with this method. Higher fatigue leads to lower quality workouts and possibly less muscle mass, particularly when combined with low protein. It can also lead people who are prone to it to bingeing. This does not mean that you can't fast from time to time if you really enjoy it.





## ADJUSTING CALORIES

### **Weigh in process:**

First thing in the morning after waking up, use the restroom and do not eat anything. In underwear or nude step on the scale. Record this weight with a date beside it. This could be in a notes app, tracking app, excel spreadsheet, but you should be able to see all prior weigh-ins.

The first 1-2 weeks of weigh-ins will not tell you nearly as much as the weeks to follow. This is simply due to the fact that most people will lose a good amount of water weight when they begin a calorie deficit or even simply eating higher quality food. The initial 5-10lbs that people drop at the beginning of a fat loss phase is NOT all fat. While you can take note of the large loss, do not mistake it for an incredibly large deficit. Once the weight loss slows down after the initial drop, you can monitor changes more effectively.



**Example:**

09/01 - 250.0 (begins 2400cal)  
09/02 - 247.6  
09/03 - 245.8  
09/04 - 244.4  
09/05 - 243.8  
09/06 - 243.6  
09/07 - 243.0  
09/08 - 242.6  
09/09 - 242.6  
09/10 - 242.0  
09/11 - 242.2  
09/12 - 241.8  
09/13 - 241.4  
09/14 - 241.8

**+** This is a very typical scale reflection of someone starting a fat loss phase. Initially you see the person losing pounds by the day. After a few days it is not as rapid, but you can still see they are losing quite quickly. By day 14 they have had three weigh-ins in a row all within the 241s. Does this mean they have plateaued? Absolutely not. But they will no longer see the 5+lbs of weight loss per week they saw initially. This will be more representative of the true deficit they are in. And while it's not a perfect way to view it, each pound of weight loss you see on the scale can fairly reasonably be thought of as somewhere between 3k-4kcal of a deficit if it is happening consistently over many weeks.





**An even better way to view it is by looking at this same person with more long term data. Suppose they continued their fat loss journey at 2400cal for the following 2 months. Their weigh ins in November look like this:**

11/14 - 233.8

11/15 - 234.0

11/16 - 233.6

**+** If these were the numbers we were looking at, it would be fairly accurate to say they lost approximately 8lbs in 2 months. This would likely mean that they were averaging a deficit of at least 300cal/day, but most likely not above 600cal/day. We would expect more weight loss if they were in a 600+cal deficit. And we would expect less weight loss if their deficit was under 300cal. This gives us very valuable insight moving forwards.

From here they can decide whether they want to increase calories, decrease, or keep them the same. If losing approximately 1% of bodyweight per week, it is probably not wise to decrease cals further. So in this particular case, this individual could decrease their calories further if they so desired. HOWEVER, this is where reflection becomes important. If you are dealing with a lot of hunger, it is unwise to increase the deficit. You are simply making yourself more prone for a rebound at that point. This is not a race. Assuming you are consistent, this is plenty of loss per week to make meaningful differences over the course of time.





Now if you are losing less than this amount, but still losing, you have a choice. Continue to lose at a slower rate, or simply speed things up by dropping an amount of calories that makes sense. For example, if you are losing at a rate of 0.5lb/week and are looking to get that number closer to 1.5, you would want to reduce calories by approximately 600. The math will not always work out perfectly, but that will cause significantly more fat loss. If you're looking to increase from 0.5 to 1lb/week, somewhere around 300 cal less will do.

**Just make sure BEFORE you adjust calories out of excitement that you're mentally ready to handle a sharper drop. It's better to lose slower and consistently than to overestimate yourself and begin yo-yo dieting.**

A very important distinction I should make at this time!!!!!!

If you are a woman, particularly a smaller woman, do NOT try to lose weight at the same rate of large men. I see women online constantly crying over 4-6lbs of weight loss in a month. That is FANTASTIC loss. You shouldn't expect your 5'4" 160lb frame to lose at the same rate as the 6'1" 300lb man. Keep realistic expectations always.

**Now let's move onto some practical application**



# SETTING UP YOUR MACROS

## Questions that you need to ask yourself:

1. Will I eat the same thing 7 days a week every week?
2. Do I have a quality budget for food?
3. Do I have time to cook?
4. Am I a picky eater?
5. Do I attend lots of social events that revolve around high calorie foods?
6. How long is this journey going to be?
7. Am I a disciplined person?

Now you might answer some of these questions one way just to find out in three weeks that you're not who you thought you were. That's totally fine. You can adjust later if necessary. But these honest questions will help you set yourself up for longer term success.



The first thing you need to figure out is your caloric starting point. From there we want to figure out macronutrients that make sense. We can quibble over how much protein is necessary in order to build muscle...but guess what? That doesn't really matter in this context. Because I'm always going to tell someone who is in fat loss to try to get over their lean mass in protein. If you're not sure what your lean mass amount is because you have a lot of bodyfat, base your MINIMUM protein amount off of your height/sex.

**MALE:**

|      |      |
|------|------|
| 5'3" | 135g |
| 5'6" | 150g |
| 5'9" | 165g |
| 6'0" | 185g |
| 6'3" | 205g |
| 6'6" | 230g |

**FEMALE:**

|      |      |
|------|------|
| 4'9" | 90g  |
| 5'0" | 100g |
| 5'3" | 115g |
| 5'6" | 130g |
| 5'9" | 145g |
| 6'0" | 165g |





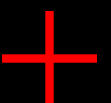
The next macronutrient that I prioritize is dietary fat. Dietary fat plays a critical role in hormone function and is often neglected in fat loss phases. My recommendation for men is around  $\frac{1}{3}$  of their lean mass minimum in grams. For women I am more apt to have that number closer to  $\frac{1}{2}$  of their lean mass. Here is another APPROXIMATE height scale you can use to calculate your fat amounts.

**MALE:**

|      |     |
|------|-----|
| 5'3" | 45g |
| 5'6" | 52g |
| 5'9" | 60g |
| 6'0" | 70g |
| 6'3" | 81g |
| 6'6" | 93g |

**FEMALE:**

|      |     |
|------|-----|
| 4'9" | 45g |
| 5'0" | 50g |
| 5'3" | 57g |
| 5'6" | 65g |
| 5'9" | 74g |
| 6'0" | 85g |





This only leaves one major macronutrient to speak of. Carbs. I call carbs the “gap filler”. We know we are aiming for a minimum of protein and fat and a maximum of a certain number of calories. So we must make the carbs fit into the overall structure. Let’s use our 5’6” female as an example. Suppose she used the height scale for her protein and fat. Let’s also assume she weighs 200lbs. She decides to multiply her weight by 10 to get her starting number for calories.

### **CURRENT PLAN:**

2000cal

130g protein

65g fat

? carbs

+ Based on the calories contained in fat and protein (9 and 4 respectively) that means 585cal from fat and 520cal from protein. Now these are MINIMUMS, so they could be higher. But if this woman were to only consume the minimum amounts, she would have 890 additional calories to work with that come from carbs.

**890/4 IS 222.5**

So 222g of carbs to reach an overall intake of 2000cal.





This structure should allow you to determine your exact calories and macros to start your journey. Once you have these laid out, it's imperative to understand that they are general guidelines. Far too often I see people just toss their hands up when they come to an out of the ordinary circumstance.

**You do NOT have to be perfect to continue to make progress.**

If you go to a restaurant and they give you the calories, but no macros, ESTIMATE. If they give you no calories or macros, ESTIMATE. Over time you will become better at this. If you can get a general estimate on protein and calories, but are unsure of the fat/carb breakdown DON'T STRESS. What you do consistently is far more important than what you do inconsistently. And if your carbs are a little high one day and your fats are a little low, it's no big deal.



# BASE DIETS

Now that we've given a general overview of types of foods and macro breakdown, we can decide what a solid approach to dieting can be. **Failing to prepare is preparing to fail.** Too many people try to "wing it" when it comes to diets and have zero overall structure. They hear a caloric deficit is all that's necessary and run with it. Which would be the case for tissue loss...if we stuck to it. But calories in calories out cares not about health, body composition or SUSTAINABILITY. Base diets fix this. This is a structured diet that you do nearly every day to help keep yourself on track. For some these will be relatively strict, for others a slightly looser format can be helpful.

If you would rather take all the information I gave you and simply "flexible diet" every day not caring about your sources for the macros, that's your call. But I have found that the food choices help tremendously with every part of the process.

Here is how you can set it up relative to the VMFCOJ method. Understand all of these values can be adapted up or down based on preferences, budget, etc. But this is a method I have found to consistently yield solid results for myself and people I have worked with. As I go along, I am going to give you a reference individual to see what this would look like applied.

# THE SUBJECT: JOHN SMITH

John Smith is our subject. He weighs 210lbs and is 5'9". His goal is weight loss and he is not incredibly muscular (likely around 150lbs lean mass). He multiplied his weight by 11 to get his starting calories of approximately 2300. He used the default amounts based on his height to get minimum macros of 165g protein minimum and 60g fat minimum. Let's see what this method would look like applied to him.



## V IS FOR VEGGIES

Let's start here. Because this is by far the most satiating food calorie for calorie, you want to have a baseline amount of calories you are getting for vegetables. I have found that somewhere between 100-500cal worth is a good starting point. People who deal with excessive hunger and/or are larger individuals will want their starting point to be higher while those not dealing with excessive hunger can be a little more lax. BUT, they should still have a baseline of 100ish cal for the benefits it can provide from a fiber, micronutrient and appetite suppression standpoint.

For John he decides that he is going to get 250cal worth of vegetables a day. The vegetables he has decided to incorporate are green beans, asparagus, broccoli, and spinach.





## M IS FOR MEAT

Obviously if you're coming from a more restrictive standpoint as a vegan, or vegetarian this will look slightly different, but the primary emphasis here is high protein items. For this section it is more based on the gram amount of protein than precise calories. We have been so conditioned to be scared of fat that we assume we have to eat the absolute leanest cut of meat possible. How will we be able to fill our calories up with carbs if we don't??? That's the secret. Especially in fat loss, high carbs should not be the priority. Now if you are going with the absolute fattiest cut of every single meat every single time, it will run your calories up fast. But there should be a solid way for you to come up with a good blend of leaner and fattier meat/seafood/egg options that have you hitting your protein without being ridiculously high in calories. Here the 1:8 ratio can be very helpful.

The 1:8 ratio is a reference to the number of grams of protein relative to calories. There are 4cal/g of protein so that means 50% of your meat/seafood/egg calories will come from protein while the other 4cal will come from fat. Some of your sources will have a slightly higher protein ratio. While some sources may be slightly higher in fat. So as long as it settles in that overall 1:8 ratio, you're likely going to be hitting fairly close to protein and fat goals simultaneously.



**Here is an example for John**

6 eggs

8oz skinless chicken thigh (cooked)

4oz salmon (cooked)

6oz 93/7 ground beef (cooked)

All of these foods logged gives us approximately 70g of fat and 180g of protein and 1400cal. He didn't have to eat only egg whites, chicken breast, and tuna to reach protein goals. Now if he preferred to have leaner cuts of meat and get his fat sources elsewhere that would be totally fine. We just want to make sure he is not neglecting fats in his diet.

Overall this means that 1400cal are coming from meat and 250 cal are coming from veggies. So far his base diet is 1650 total cals. Now if he wanted to leave the base diet as just that, that would be completely fine. He would be hitting his protein and fat minimums as well as getting fiber from the vegetables. Everything past this point is optional.





## **F IS FOR FRUIT**

If he wanted to add in fruit for additional satiety it definitely is not a bad idea. So this can be added into the base diet. And IF he is incredibly picky, he might possibly consider swapping some vegetable calories for fruit calories. Personally I believe he should keep the fruit and vegetable cals separate if possible, but this is a minor detail in the grand scheme of things.

For John a good idea would be to get approximately 150cal worth of his day through fruit. There are many ways to go about this. But very simplistically put, he should choose fruits that give him the biggest bang for buck in terms of enjoyment and long term satisfaction. If he loves strawberries it could be as simple as 1lb of strawberries.

Overall this means that 1400cal are meat, 250cal are veg, and 150cal are fruit. This is a really solid format for the base diet and will be far more likely to lead to longterm success both in body composition outcomes and satiety than simply winging a protocol.





## **COJ** IS FOR CARBS, OILS, AND JUNK

This likely will NOT be a part of the base diet. These are the leftovers. The gap fillers to reach 2300cals. If John would rather continue to fill the cals with VMF foods, that is completely fine. But many people like to have some of these types of foods added into their diet to help them mentally. And that is totally FINE. There are times to be regimented and times to relax. Having this option of 500 more cals to go towards whatever they desire can be freeing for a lot of people. But if he genuinely preferred dieting in a way that has less flexibility, sweet potatoes, potatoes, whole grains are all solid choices for this category. They provide more than just calories and are likely going to be more satiating than other carbs like white rice/pasta. And yes he can still incorporate those into his diet. Not EVERY SINGLE calorie has to be the most nutrient dense and filling food in the world.



# MOVING BEYOND THE FORMULA

Be rigid when necessary to achieve goals and flexible when necessary to achieve sustainability. This can be a delicate balance for a lot of people and you may find that there is a method quite different from the one outlined here that works for you (while the mechanism of fat loss will be the same). In the end there are common traits shared amongst people who lose weight and keep it off long term. I am merely giving you general strategies that I have seen to be quite effective.

Here are some principles healthy populations share that we commonly see in the literature that can help influence the way you approach fat loss.

## **Fiber:**

Those that make fiber a priority within their diet are statistically more likely to lose weight and keep it off.

## **Protein:**

Those that make protein a priority are statistically more likely to lose fat and keep it off as well as build/maintain muscle



### **Whole foods:**

Those who consistently opt for whole foods are less likely to become or stay overweight. Not only this, but when subjects within studies are given the opportunity to eat freely with whole foods or processed foods, even short term we see they consistently eat more calories from the processed food than whole.

### **Activity:**

Those who are more active generally speaking have a decreased risk of all cause mortality. Based on the current literature, it appears that the benefits continue to increase all the way up to 300-600min/week of moderate physical activity, while vigorous physical activity increases benefits up to 150-299min/week. While this might not directly point to lower bodyfat, I believe it would be safe to assume that it also plays a role in body composition.

### **Steps:**

There is a consistent theme in the literature of those who get more steps tending to have lower BMIs than those who get less. Now could it be possible that those who are obese tend to walk less? Of course. But having goals for yourself in terms of general activity that lead to higher step counts can be incredibly helpful.

The reason I bring these up is due to people's insistence on ignoring variables beyond calories. Calories are the MECHANISM, but simply understanding calories has not led to long term outcomes on a population scale. The things that have are outlined above. So you would be foolish to ignore them in favor of only looking at the calories you consume. You wouldn't consider me a good coach if I gave you a manual on how to win in basketball and I said "just put the ball in the hoop more than the other team". That is the equivalent of telling people to just consume less calories. While it isn't wrong, getting and staying there is tough without a solid approach.

# BUILDING MUSCLE

This is an area of specialty of mine, however this manual is not specifically geared towards this topic. As such, we will keep this very broad. Perhaps there will be a manual in the future where I can cover the nuances of muscle building. For now, these are the general things I want you to keep in mind.

Your goal when you do any form of resistance training should be a few things:

## **SOLID EXERCISE SELECTION**

If you are just throwing a sandbag around, that might make you better at throwing a sandbag around. But there are much more efficient ways to target muscle groups for growth. As such, if your goal is to build/maintain muscle, you should have movements that you know will work those muscle groups well AND that you perform consistently.

**Basic examples include:**

|                               |                                                                     |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Chest Press:                  | Chest                                                               |
| Flys:                         | Chest                                                               |
| Shoulder Press:               | Front and Side Deltoids                                             |
| Pulldowns/Pullups:            | Lats                                                                |
| Rows (elbows flared):         | Traps and Rhomboids                                                 |
| Shrug Variations:             | Traps                                                               |
| Bicep Curls:                  | Biceps                                                              |
| Tricep Extensions:            | Triceps                                                             |
| Straight Leg Calf Raises:     | Calves                                                              |
| Hamstring Curls:              | Hamstrings                                                          |
| Leg Press/Squatting Patterns: | Quads/Adductors/Glutes                                              |
| Leg Extension:                | Quads                                                               |
| Lateral Raises:               | Side delts                                                          |
| Hinge Pattern Movements:      | Glutes/Hamstrings/Erectors<br>Adductors (varies depending on hinge) |
| Adductor Machine:             | Adductors                                                           |

This obviously doesn't cover every aspect of exercise selection, but if you have a solid blend of these exercises you are doing throughout the week, you will be well on your way to building a solid physique.





## INTENSITY

In order for muscle to grow it needs to be given a reason. You use your arms to unload the dishwasher, but I'm sure you haven't noticed any appreciable growth from it. The reason is simple. There is not enough intensity behind those movements to cause adaptation. We could get very nuanced on this conversation, but the most important thing you need to know is that the repetitions of the exercises outlined above that you take to failure or close to it, are the repetitions that lead to growth.

If you pick up the lightest dumbbell in the gym and do 5 bicep curls, but you were CAPABLE of doing 30 reps, you will not grow from that. If you pick up a heavier dumbbell, and you do 5 bicep curls but you could have done 6 reps if you had pushed yourself as hard as possible, you have a good chance of growing from that set. A good rule of thumb while training is to choose a weight that you could not do for more than 10 reps even if your life was on the line and then perform the exercise until you hit failure or are within 1-2 reps of failure. This baseline knowledge will allow you to make the majority of your muscular progress overtime. Smaller nuances will allow you to maximize it. But that is for another manual.





## FREQUENCY

From the current literature it appears that training a muscle group once per week is ENOUGH to cause muscle growth. HOWEVER, there is a possibility you may grow more muscle by training a muscle group 2-3x/ week. That's it. That's all you need to know about this.

## VOLUME

When I say volume I am simply referring to the number of sets you do for a muscle group in a week. There are direct and indirect sets. For example, while a pulldown may not be a biceps focused exercise, they are still going to be involved to a significant degree. Long story short, do not feel like you need to do crazy numbers of sets for muscles in order to see significant growth. Now exactly how much volume one does is going to depend on a few factors. Some people are incredibly specific about their volume amounts and that is perfectly fine.

But if you are simply looking to build some muscle, even a lot of muscle, don't feel like your volume has to be an incredibly specific amount. My general recommendations are to work muscle groups for approximately 5 sets per week spread across multiple days. From there you can increase volume if you would like. But if it's working, there usually isn't a need to change. So what does "working" mean?





## PROGRESSIVE OVERLOAD

One of the ways we can tell our workouts are trending in the right direction is through objective standards. If technique for the exercise remains the same, but you are able to increase the number of repetitions, this is an example of progressive overload. Another example is if you are able to increase the amount of weight you use for the exercise, but your number of repetitions stays the same or increases. Your body has made an adaptation that has allowed you to perform at a higher level. This does NOT automatically mean you have gained muscle. There are neurological adaptations that can happen as well. However, if you continue to progress these exercises over a long period of time, it is a great indicator that you are building muscle.

An important thing to note is being in a caloric deficit can make it harder to progressively overload. So if you are in a specific fat loss phase and your lifts aren't increasing but are remaining close to the same, do NOT view this as a waste of time. Because these workouts are what are going to allow you to maintain your muscle while losing fat.

## CONCLUDING REMARKS

And that is all you truly need to know about muscle for now. Yes it can be more nuanced. My platform is largely based upon the nuances of muscle building. But if you can follow and understand these principles, you will be able to build a very solid amount of muscle over time.

# PART 2

**WHEN THE  
DIET IS OVER...  
IT'S NOT**

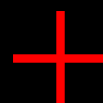


This is the biggest mistake people make when they have achieved their “goal weight” or “goal physique”. They breathe. Now don’t get me wrong, you SHOULD be happy. You should be ecstatic to have gone through the process successfully. **But if you do not understand that it is merely the first step in the process, you will inevitably turn back to old habits, perhaps even worse ones which will lead to very rapid weight gain, frustration and confusion when all the progress you made seemingly disappears.**

This sounds bleak, and it is. In fact this is what happens to the majority of people who experience significant weight loss. They do not keep it off. This is why the diet is not over, and this is why you need to heed my words for the next steps. And this is going to very heavily hinge on... VMFCOJ. You see, people think of appetite and appetite suppression in terms of calories when it is FAR more complex than that. The most common path that people take coming out of a fat loss phase is to eat foods they weren’t previously eating. “Man I’ve missed this...”

There are a couple reasons we do this and many reasons why it is a horrible idea. One of the reasons we do this is because we think things are over. We accomplished the task and therefore think we don’t need to worry about all the things we did to accomplish said task. It makes sense. We did the diet. So why do we need to keep dieting? We weren’t doing it before we began the fat loss phase. We got down to the weight/look we want to be. Therefore...pizza.

Unfortunately our brain doesn’t want it to be that easy. Various hunger cues kick up over the course of a dieting phase and can become quite extreme. The easiest way to illustrate this pattern of behavior is to give a tangible example. Let’s use our previous example 5’9” John. John started at 210lbs and cut down to 160. If you think it is odd that he went all the way down to 160, you likely have a skewed perspective on how little muscle and how much fat the average person has on their frame. He was smart and took a diet break around 180lbs for two weeks before continuing his journey to 160lbs.





At the end of this fat loss journey he was getting 15k steps a day and eating 2000cal. For the last 4 weeks he averaged 0.75lbs of weight loss. If we reverse engineer this we can tell he was in APPROXIMATELY a 300 cal deficit. Due to waste, water, and other factors, you are never going to be able to give an EXACT deficit. This is just a general framework that we can work within in order to make decisions moving forward.

**If we had simply based our math off of 3500cal fat in 1lb this is how the math would work.**

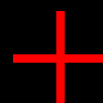
He lost 3lbs over the last 4 weeks

$3500\text{cal} \times 3 = 10500\text{cal}$  for those 4 weeks

If we divide 10500cal by the number of days (28) we arrive at 375cal/day

Like I said, this is NOT a perfect number, but it provides good framing for the next step. In order to put John around maintenance calories for the next bit which is what you SHOULD do coming out of a fat loss phase, we would want to increase his calories around this amount or slightly higher. In this case anywhere between a 350-500 cal increase would make sense. HOWEVER, if you do not continue with the same level of activity, this does not work. If you immediately drop your steps from 15k/day to 5k/day, you should also expect a significant reduction in calories that you expend.

This is often why people gain so much weight coming out of fat loss. They have multiple strikes against them. They significantly increase calories, decrease previous activity levels AND, and this is the most important one, they do NOT stick to the calories they initially planned. And this often comes as a direct result of poor dietary choices. They immediately incorporate plenty of foods in the COJ category rather than simply increasing the amount of VMF.





Until your body has settled into a rhythm, it makes far more sense to increase cals primarily through VMF until hunger becomes a non issue. This can take TIME. And many people are too impatient to let it happen. As you become more in control of your hunger, incorporating more foods that fall into the COJ categories can be something you do with much more control and with an ability to maintain caloric needs without blowing through them.

The easiest way to go about this is to keep the base diet through this next phase. For some this will last a week or two, for others it CAN last months to truly settle down. During this time you should not only be tracking your weight. You should also be taking progress photos. Due to the ability to continue progressing in the gym, often people will find themselves gaining muscle at a rate that will cause them to build muscle while at maintenance or lower.

There WILL likely be an increase in weight that happens directly after increasing calories. If this happens, do NOT panic. It is normal. This is glycogen and waste building up in the system. So weeks 1 and 2 following fat loss and entering maintenance mode should NOT be used to determine if you are in a surplus or deficit. From weeks 3 onwards begin to pay close attention to your weight. What you want to see is either a complete stabilization or under 0.5lbs of weight gain per week.

The reasoning behind this is simple. Stabilized weight suggests you are close to maintenance where under 0.5lbs weight gain suggests you are not gaining weight so rapidly that you can't put a good amount of it towards productive training and muscle building. **No matter what the scale says your objective should remain the same as it was through weight loss.** BETTER gym performance as indicated through progressive overload.



# AFTER HUNGER IS SUCCESSFULLY MANAGED

Read the last part before this as many times as you need in order for it to sink in. Hunger MUST be managed for long term weight loss to be successful and enjoyable. Could you theoretically just stay hungry the rest of your life? Of course. But if unnecessary suffering is what you're after, ignore everything I've said. We on the same page? Good. Let's continue forward.



## “BULKING”

The reason put bulking in quotations is because I want you to get rid of that term from your thinking. Or at the very least, I want you to begin to add the following terminology into your mind.

## BUILDING PHASE

This is a more apt descriptor of what comes next. The primary objective during this time is to build muscle. NOT gain weight. Inevitably at some point in this process you are likely, if not required to gain weight. But that should not be the first objective. Due to this, the objective should be to eat in a way that facilitates solid gym performance and recovery. What does this look like? Adequate energy, adequate micronutrition, and adequate protein. The EXACT same things as is required to go through a successful fat loss phase. The biggest difference is the definition of “adequate” in each scenario.





Adequate energy intake in fat loss is a deficit that allows you to lose fat at a reasonable rate while not completely degrading muscle. Adequate energy intake in a building phase is an amount of food that allows you to progress muscularly at a rate that makes sense. For example. Many people CAN build muscle in a 100-300cal deficit. But they likely will not build at the rate of a 0-200cal surplus. The reason I include zero is because body recomp is not just for people who have never lifted before. It is also for those that have enough bodyfat in order to repurpose it towards the energetic processes involved in muscle building.

Think of it as a probability curve.

**Gaining weight:** You almost INDEFINITELY are going to be consuming enough to be anabolic. Preferably, you want more of it going towards muscle than fat, but you're definitely getting enough energy to build muscle.

**Maintaining weight:** You will likely be in an anabolic state muscularly (assuming you have adequate health/fat stores/sleep/nutrition), but the likelihood is reduced. The likelihood of MAXIMIZING muscular progress is also reduced.

**Losing weight:** You MIGHT be in an anabolic state muscularly, but the likelihood is reduced to an even greater degree. You almost certainly are NOT maximizing muscular progress.

**Rapidly losing weight:** You are almost certainly not in an anabolic state muscularly (adding ADDITIONAL muscle). And I can also say with 99.9% certainty that you aren't maximizing muscle growth in this state.

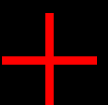




This is why your caloric intake should be dictated on progress rather than an arbitrary number on the scale. To make an extreme example, if you are 170lbs and bench 225lbs, but then you progress your bench to 315lbs while maintaining 170lbs, you almost certainly have added muscle. How is this possible? You lost fat AND built muscle. BUT do not expect to be able to do recomp indefinitely. This is why progression should dictate calories to a point.

Let's use John to explain this again. John is now sitting at a comfortable maintenance of 165lbs on 2500cal/day. Sleep is fantastic, workouts are progressing solidly and he has plenty of energy. There is NO reason to increase calories at this time. Especially if John was smart about his fat loss and didn't go down to single digit bodyfat. Now over time progression will slow. At this point he should reassess his caloric intake. **Here is a VERY IMPORTANT point. He does NOT need to do major increases in calories when this happens.** He should increase his calories by approximately 100 (from 2500-2600) and then continue on. If progress picks up in the next couple weeks, he can keep cals at 2600. If there is no pick up in progress after a few weeks, increase by 100 again.

**This process should be slow. The LAST thing you want to do is rush through a building phase. You almost certainly will gain more fat than you desire in a short amount of time and will feel like you need to go back into a fat loss phase.** This will have you oscillating back and forth so often that you don't make nearly the progress that you would if you simply slowed down the building phase. Eventually this using of calories to POTENTIATE growth will have your weight going up over time. If you find that you are gaining weight at a rate faster than 0.5lbs/week and still not progressing your lifts the answer is likely not to increase cals.





At that point you should evaluate your training or your perspective on what reasonable rate of progress is rather than blaming the amount of food you are consuming. After you have been in the gym for a couple years with solid training principles, muscle building is SLOW. If you think you're simply going to force muscle growth with large caloric increases, you have the wrong idea on what calories do. And if you've read this far in the manual you're likely not the type of person to struggle to overeat as is so do NOT give yourself that excuse.

If you do things properly you should be able to stay at a solid healthy body fat for the rest of your life after one cut. Now if you decide to compete in bodybuilding or decide to test your limits and get truly shredded (sub 10% bodyfat), that's perfectly fine. Just understand that you likely won't feel or perform your best so do not expect to stay there.

## CONCLUDING REMARKS

I appreciate all the support you guys have given me and I hope this can help you to take control of your body composition once and for all! I understand that being meticulous with numbers can become anxiety inducing for some, so if you ever feel it trending that way for yourself PLEASE speak to someone. This is not about being the perfect human being. It's about giving yourself the tools to take control, not BE controlled. If you don't already, follow me on tiktok and IG (TikTok may be banned by the time you see this) and ask lots of questions so we can grow together!

- TNF out